THE SLOP CHECK SHEET

Diagnose it. Repair it. Stay in charge of it.

A COMPANION TO THE GUIDE
STOP THE SLOP
FREE · FOR TEACHERS

Use this on any teaching resource you are about to put in front of a class, whether an AI helped make it or you wrote it yourself. **Slop**, as the guide uses the word, means output that hasn't been adequately examined, tested and improved for its intended use. It isn't defined by who or what made it.

1 · LOOK FIRST: THE QUICK CHECK

- ☐ **One page, on its own.** Can you start? Is everything you need on it?
- ☐ **The lazy way.** Can you finish without the thinking you intended?
- ☐ **Pages side by side.** Names, numbers, situation and who holds what agree.
- ☐ **Answers.** Solve them yourself, then compare with the key. Numbering matches.
- ☐ **Teacher notes, exactly as written.** What to print, page numbers, timings.
- ☐ **Who gets a copy of this page?** No answers or teacher notes on student pages.
- ☐ **The exported file.** Open it. Look at every page.
- ☐ **Write down each problem** with its page and line.

2 · SYMPTOM FIRST, CAUSE SECOND

A symptom is what you notice. A cause is your best explanation, and it stays a hypothesis until you've checked it.

SYMPTOM	POSSIBLE CAUSES (TO INVESTIGATE)	CONTROLLED REPAIR	RE-CHECK
Pages contradict each other	Pages may have been drafted separately, with no shared situation fixed	State the shared facts once; correct only the page that disagrees	Both student sheets, notes, key
Page references or page count don't match the file	Notes may predate the layout, or the layout may have changed since	Settle the layout, then correct the references; reflow if lines have spilled over	Each reference against the real page order
Students can finish without the thinking you intended	The task may need no decision, or one detail may give the answer away	No decision: return to your plan. A giveaway: change only that detail	Solve it as a student hunting for the quickest route
Answers appear on a page students will receive	Answers may share a page with student material, or a pattern may point to them	Move teacher material to its own page; remove the pattern	For each page: who gets a copy?
Answers still findable in the file after being covered	A box may have been drawn over the text, hiding it without removing it	Rebuild the page without the answers	Search the exported file for a word from an answer; check any preview
A repair changed things you didn't ask for	The request may not have said what to keep	Say what must stay; ask what changed; undo unwanted changes	Compare old and new yourself
Wording sounds unnatural	The context may have been vague	Rewrite only the marked lines, saying who is speaking to whom	Read it aloud as the student would
Language is above or below your students' level	Your students' level may not have been stated, or the AI's idea of it may differ from yours	Replace or pre-teach the hard words; ask for simpler versions of those lines only	Read as a student; check key and notes still match
A fact may be wrong	Fluent text isn't evidence; the AI may have stated something false or out of date	Check a reliable source; correct or remove only that claim	Every other place the fact appears
Meaning depends on colour	The design may have assumed colour printing	Add a label, border or symbol	Print one page in black and white

If copying or matching is the point of the task, "students can finish by copying" is not a problem.

REPAIR IT, THEN DECIDE

3 · SORT THE PROBLEM

Cosmetic: nobody would be misled.
Local: one named place is wrong and you can say what right looks like.
Structural: the task isn't doing what you wanted, or problems depend on each other.

Local problems suit a controlled repair. For structural ones, go back to your plan.

4 · CONTROLLED REPAIR, STEP BY STEP

1. **Pin down the symptom:** page, line, what you saw.
2. **Investigate the likely cause:** list two or three possibilities and check the cheapest first.
3. **Define what must not change:** answers, numbering, page order, particular wording.
4. **Make the smallest appropriate repair:** one defect at a time.
5. **Check the repair and what depends on it:** key, teacher notes, numbering, page count and order, repeated information, matching versions (A/B, easier/harder).
6. **Inspect the finished output:** open the exported file; print a copy if you'll hand it out on paper.
7. **Decide:** retain, revise or discard.

5 · RETAIN, REVISE OR DISCARD

RETAIN
The problem is fixed, the dependencies check out, the finished output looks right and you'd hand it to a colleague.

REVISE
A repair worked but exposed another local problem. Carry on while each fix stays small and you can say what it touched.

DISCARD AND RESTART
Repairs keep creating problems elsewhere, you can't say what the task now is, or the problem is structural. Keep the plan. The draft is the disposable part.

6 · THREE DIFFERENT CHECKS OF THE FILE

CHECK	IT SHOWS	IT DOESN'T SHOW
On screen, in your editor or the AI's preview	What you made	What the exported file contains
The exported PDF, opened	Page count, order, breaks, text	How a printer reproduces it
A physical print	Margins, legibility, shading, double-sided	Whether students understand the task

None stands in for the others. After any repair, export again and look at the whole file.

7 · KEEP A MISTAKES LOG

One line each time a check or repair finds a problem: what went wrong, then the rule that would have prevented it. A mistake that survives one repair is worth a rule.

MISTAKE	RULE
Teacher notes said "print pages 1 and 2" but the student sheets were on pages 1 and 3	Check every page reference against the exported file

BEFORE YOU PASTE ANYTHING INTO AN AI SERVICE

Check the service's terms, your school's policy, and what you are allowed to share. DfE guidance for England (updated 12 August 2025) recommends that personal data is not used in generative AI tools. Don't paste identifiable pupil information unless you've checked that it's permitted. This is not legal advice (see Chapter 12 of the guide).

What this sheet is not. *It is a condensed reference, not a validated method. The checks in the guide haven't been timed or tested in classrooms, and the guide records no classroom trial of its examples. It cannot tell you whether your students will understand a task. That is why you still try it.*